

Musically Yours

Five major recording companies have introduced file sharing services of their own—Pressplay courtesy Sony and Vivendi Universal, and MusicNet from AOL Time Warner, EMI, Bertelsmann's BMG, and RealNetworks. Both services allow users limited access to portions of their catalogues for \$10 a month. MusicNet is available through AOL, RealNetworks and Napster, while Pressplay is linked on MSN Music, MP3.com, and Yahoo Music.

Both MusicNet and Pressplay will be streaming

and download services. Unlike free services, both music services suffer from huge gaps in their selection of music, and their collection is less than comprehensive.

Both the services are mutually exclusive, and music under independent labels isn't available. The music collection on both services looks like a mail order catalogue.

Another problem is that music downloaded from Pressplay or MusicNet won't play on anything except the PC that downloaded it. Burning the files onto a CD or transferring them onto an MP3 player is also not possible.

year preceding it. The International Federation of the Phonographic Industry (IFPI) announced that global sales of recorded music fell by 5 per cent in 2001. While the general economic situation could be one reason for the decline, the IFPI insisted that illegal copying of music across the Internet was also to blame.

In a contrasting report made by Jupiter Media Metrix, Internet users who download songs from P2P services are more likely to increase their music purchases than regular Internet users. According to the report, 34 per cent of P2P users said they spent more money on music than they did before they used such services, while 15 per cent said they spent less. One-half said the amount of money they spent remained the same.

The report showed that music fans who did not use file-sharing services were less likely to report increased spending. Nineteen per cent said they spent more money on music, while 10 per cent said they spent less and 71 per cent said they spent the same amount. In fact, the biggest impact of digital music may turn out to be the fact that it

will drive more people to their local music stores with well-researched shopping lists.

Music companies however are preoccupied with making frantic attempts to ensure that consumers continue to pay for music even as technology makes it

increasingly easy to copy and transfer digital music. These attempts range from music with expiry dates that would work for a certain amount of time to digital 'watermarks', which prevent copies from being made.

In a recent report carried out by an Internet data measurement firm, ComScore Networks, for the month of February, Morpheus attracted 37 million visitors worldwide, KaZaA garnered 25 million, and Audiogalaxy 20 million, while Pressplay brought in only 788,000 and MusicNet got a piddling 154,000. As is evident, the legitimate services have a long way to go. ■

SRIRAM SHARMA

program where you use its Web site to select which songs to download, while the client facilitates the transfer. The client program is small and simple, designed to use a minimum of CPU and memory resources. The Satellite automatically selects the closest user carrying the file you want, reducing external bandwidth usage. Popular and easy to use, Audiogalaxy allows you to resume downloads. Most copyrighted music is blocked, although you can dig deeper and find your song if you're persistent.



Direct Connect

www.neo-modus.com

Unlike other file-sharing networks, Direct Connect offers a community-oriented approach to a user-controlled network. While Direct Connect's network architecture is built on a peer-to-peer foundation, the users run, control and maintain the network. Users are able to share any kind of file—absolutely no restrictions. This service is useful for those with a lot of spare bandwidth at their disposal.



Edonkey

www.Edonkey2000.com

More of a movie and a game swapping ring than an MP3 service, Edonkey's popularity comes from the vast number of servers run by anonymous individuals. At a given time, Edonkey has at least a hundred servers running all over the world. Edonkey uses file hashing, which breaks a large file into smaller shareable chunks, and allows

simultaneous uploading and downloading of files. It allows auto resume of files from any source.



iMesh

www.iMesh.com

Israel-based iMesh routes requests through a central server and allows access to video and image files apart from MP3s. Downloads are very fast and can be resumed later if a file's owner disconnects. iMesh allows you to download files from up to seven users simultaneously. You can complete downloads even if the original owner goes offline during file transfer. It's not as popular as Audiogalaxy or Gnutella-based applications, but it is one of the oldest surviving P2P services.



OpenNap

<http://opennet.sourceforge.net>

OpenNap is an open source version of Napster that looks and works basically like Napster, but allows various individual sites to create their own interlocking Napster networks. It's been written by programmers who reverse-engineered the Napster protocol.

Money for nothing

The year 2001 was the first year when sales of CDs were lower than the

By the end of 2002, there will be only about 8 million MP3 capable devices in consumers' hands